SAMPLE

Khadijah: The First Believer

The Mother of the Believers and the First to Accept Islam

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Introduction: The First Light

In the long history of faith, there is a moment before the message spreads, before the community forms, before the battles are fought and the treaties are signed -- a moment when the Prophet stands alone. The revelation has come, the weight of prophethood has descended, and the one who was known as "the Trustworthy" (al-Amin) in the streets of Mecca now carries a burden that no human being has carried for centuries. He returns home trembling. He does not yet know what has happened to him. He does not yet know what will be asked of him. He knows only that something vast and terrifying has touched him in the cave of Hira, and that the world he knew has changed forever.

It is in this moment -- the moment of the Prophet's greatest vulnerability -- that Khadijah bint Khuwaylid speaks. She does not doubt him. She does not question him. She does not ask for proof or explanation. She speaks words that will echo through the centuries: "Never! By Allah, Allah will never disgrace you. You keep good relations with your relatives, you help the destitute, you serve your guests, and you help those in distress."

This book is about that woman -- the first person to accept Islam, the first to believe in the message of Prophet Muhammad ?, the one whose faith was not the product of argument or miracle but of intimate knowledge of a person's character. Khadijah's story is not told through a single surah of the Quran, nor through a dramatic narrative arc of prophetic confrontation. It is told through the hadith -- through the remembered moments of a life lived in the closest proximity to the Prophet, through the testimony of those who saw her faith, her generosity, her sacrifice, and her unshakable trust.

Khadijah was not a prophet. She was not a messenger. She was a woman of Mecca -- a businesswoman, a widow, a mother, a partner -- whose distinction in the sight of Allah was so great that the Prophet ? would say of her, decades after her death, that she was one of the four greatest women of all time, alongside Asiya (the wife of Pharaoh), Maryam (the mother of Isa), and Fatimah (his own daughter). He would say that the best of the women of the world were four: Maryam, Asiya, Khadijah, and Fatimah. And he would say, in a hadith that brings tears to the eyes of those who hear it, that he was given the love of Khadijah by Allah.

What made Khadijah so beloved? What made her the first? What was it about her faith, her character, her life, that earned her a place among the greatest women in the sight of the One who created all women?

This book seeks to answer that question -- not by elevating Khadijah beyond what the sources justify, but by examining what the sources actually say and drawing from them the lessons that Allah intended for us to learn. Khadijah's story is the story of faith at its most personal, most intimate, and most unwavering. It is the story of a woman who believed before there was a community to belong to, who gave before there was a guarantee of return, and who trusted before there was evidence to trust.

She is the first light of Islam -- not the light of revelation itself, which belongs to the Prophet ?, but the first light that the revelation illuminated. She is the first reflection of the message in a human heart. And in that reflection, we see what faith looks like when it is pure, when it is rooted in love, and when it is sustained through the hardest years of a Prophet's life.

Khadijah's story is also the story of what it means to be prepared. She was a hanif -- a monotheist in the tradition of Ibrahim -- before the revelation came. She was a woman of wealth and independence before she became the wife of a prophet. She was a person of faith, of character, of substance, and when the moment came -- the moment that would define the rest of her life and the course of human history -- she was ready. Her readiness was not the product of a single instant but of a lifetime of living with integrity, of seeking truth, of rejecting the idols of her society, and of trusting in the One God when trusting in the One God was an act of dissent.

This is the tenth and final book in The Honored Ones series -- a series dedicated to those whom Allah honored, who are not among the twenty-five named prophets of the Quran but whose stories are preserved in revelation and prophetic memory. Khadijah's story completes the series not because it is the most dramatic, but because it is the most personal -- the story of a woman whose faith was the first stone in the foundation of a religion that would change the world.

Chapter 1: The Woman of Mecca

Khadijah bint Khuwaylid ibn Asad ibn Abd al-Uzza ibn Qusayy al-Qurashiyyah. Her lineage runs through the heart

of the Quraysh -- the tribe that controlled the Kaaba, that governed Mecca, that claimed descent from Ibrahim through his son Ismail. She was born into the clan of Banu Asad, a respected branch of the Quraysh, and her father Khuwaylid was a man of standing and influence in Meccan society.

Her name, Khadijah, is one of those Arabic names whose etymology carries meaning within its sound. Scholars have suggested that it derives from a root associated with prematurity -- one born early -- but the significance of the name in Islamic history has nothing to do with its linguistic origin and everything to do with the person who bore it. Khadijah is not merely a name; it is a title earned through faith, through sacrifice, and through a love that the Prophet ? himself described as divinely granted.

The Qurayshi Context

To understand Khadijah, one must first understand the world she lived in. Mecca in the sixth century was a city of commerce, of tribal alliances, and of religious significance. The Kaaba stood at its center -- the house built by Ibrahim and Ismail, but now housing hundreds of idols. The Quraysh were its custodians, and their status as the keepers of the sacred house gave them prestige throughout the Arabian Peninsula.

Meccan society was structured around tribal loyalty, commercial competition, and a rigid social hierarchy. Women in this society had limited rights -- they could be inherited, they could be divorced at will, and female infants were sometimes buried alive in a practice the Quran would later condemn in the strongest terms. Yet within this society, certain women rose to positions of remarkable independence, and Khadijah was foremost among them.

The Respect She Commanded

Khadijah was known in Mecca not merely as a wealthy woman but as a woman of dignity, judgment, and wisdom. The title by which she was known before Islam -- al-Tahira, "the Pure One" -- speaks to the respect she commanded in a society that was often harsh in its judgments of women. To be called "pure" in Mecca was to be recognized as a person of moral integrity, and Khadijah earned that recognition through a life of honesty, generosity, and principled conduct.

The fact that Khadijah was given this title by a society that did not yet know Islam is significant. It means that her character was apparent to those around her -- not as a religious claim but as a social reality. The people of Mecca could see that Khadijah was different: that she conducted her business with integrity, that she treated people with fairness, and that she maintained a standard of personal conduct that set her apart. This visible character is what made her the ideal first believer -- she was already living the values that Islam would later codify.

A Woman of Independent Means

Khadijah was a businesswoman. This fact, simple as it is, carries enormous weight when placed in its context. In a society where women were often treated as property, Khadijah owned property. In a society where women's economic activity was mediated through male relatives, Khadijah conducted her own business. She was a merchant of considerable wealth, trading goods between Mecca and Syria, and she employed agents to manage her caravans.

The sources tell us that Khadijah had been married twice before her marriage to the Prophet ? -- first to Abu Halah, by whom she had children, and then to Atiq ibn A'idh. Both marriages ended -- the first through her husband's death and the second through divorce. By the time she encountered Muhammad ?, she was a widow of means, a woman who had experienced both marriage and loss, and who had established herself as one of the most successful merchants in Mecca.

This is the first thing to understand about Khadijah: she was not a naive young woman swept off her feet. She was a mature, experienced, independently wealthy woman who had navigated the complexities of Meccan society and emerged as a figure of authority and respect. Her choice to marry Muhammad ? was not a passive acceptance of a proposal -- it was the deliberate decision of a woman who had evaluated a man's character over years of business association and found him worthy.

The story of Khadijah and Muhammad ? begins not with romance but with commerce. Khadijah, aware of the young Muhammad's reputation for honesty and trustworthiness, hired him to manage one of her trade caravans to Syria. She sent him with her goods and her servant Maysarah, and the expedition was a success.

The details of this journey are preserved in the sira literature -- accounts that describe the encounter with the monk Bahira, who recognized signs of prophethood in the young Muhammad, and Maysarah's report of remarkable events during the journey. Whether every detail of these accounts is historically precise is a matter of scholarly

discussion, but the core narrative is consistent: Khadijah entrusted her business to a man whose reputation for honesty was unmatched in Mecca, and that trust was vindicated.

The Character That Preceded the Revelation

It is essential to note that Khadijah's attraction to Muhammad ? was based on character, not revelation. She knew him as a man -- as the one called "al-Amin" (the Trustworthy), as the one who kept good relations with his relatives, as the one who helped those in need. She did not know him as a prophet, because he was not yet a prophet. She married a man of integrity, and it was that same integrity -- demonstrated over years, witnessed in the ordinary moments of life -- that became the foundation of her faith when the revelation came.

This is a profound point: Khadijah's faith in the prophethood of Muhammad ? was grounded in her knowledge of his character. She did not need a miracle. She did not need a sign from heaven. She needed only to see the man she had married -- the man she had watched for years -- and to know that such a man could not fabricate a claim of divine revelation. Her faith was not credulity; it was the logical conclusion of sustained observation. She had seen his honesty in trade, his generosity with wealth, his kindness to the vulnerable, and his integrity in a society that rewarded deceit. When he came to her trembling from the cave of Hira, she did not say, "Prove it." She said, "Allah will never disgrace you."

The implication is staggering: Khadijah believed that a man of such character was automatically under divine protection. She did not derive this from theology -- she derived it from lived experience. She knew Muhammad ? as a wife knows a husband, as a businesswoman knows a partner, and as a Meccan knows a fellow citizen. And that knowledge was sufficient.

Khadijah proposed marriage to Muhammad ? -- or, according to some accounts, she sent her friend Nafisah to convey her interest. The accounts vary in their details, but the core is consistent: Khadijah, a woman of wealth and standing fifteen years his senior (according to the most common report), chose to marry a man of modest means but impeccable character. He was twenty-five; she was forty. He had little wealth; she had abundance.

The marriage was a partnership. The sources are clear that Muhammad ? did not marry Khadijah for her wealth -- he managed her business, but the relationship was one of genuine love and mutual respect. They had six children together: al-Qasim, Abdallah, Zaynab, Ruqayyah, Umm Kulthum, and Fatimah. The two sons died in infancy, and the four daughters would live to see the dawn of Islam.

For fifteen years, Khadijah and Muhammad ? lived a life of marital happiness that the sources describe in terms of extraordinary warmth. He took no other wife during her lifetime -- a remarkable fact in a society where polygyny was common among men of standing. She was his only wife, his confidante, his partner in every sense, and the years of their marriage were, by all accounts, the most peaceful and contented period of his life.

The Years Before Revelation

In the years before the revelation, Khadijah and Muhammad ? were a couple of unusual devotion. The sources tell us that Muhammad ? would retreat to the cave of Hira for periods of spiritual contemplation, and Khadijah would prepare provisions for him. She did not object to his retreats. She did not demand that he spend his time in more "productive" pursuits. She understood -- or at least accepted -- that her husband was a man drawn to solitude and worship, and she supported him in that without complaint.

This is a detail that reveals much about Khadijah's character. She was a woman of the world -- a businesswoman, a woman of social standing, a woman who could have demanded a husband more present, more conventional, more aligned with the expectations of Meccan society. Instead, she supported a man who disappeared into a cave on a mountain to contemplate and pray. She did this without understanding why, without sharing the impulse, and without any indication that the retreats would lead to anything other than personal satisfaction. She supported him because she loved him and because she trusted his judgment, even when his judgment led him in directions she did not fully comprehend.